

Founder Hackathon - Judging & Scoring Guide

AI BEAVERS x Mollie founder hackathon Hamburg, House of AI - Saturday, June 6, 2026

This guide explains how projects will be judged, what teams should optimize for, and how to make your live pitch easy to evaluate.

The short version: build something that looks like the beginning of a real startup, not only a polished hackathon project.

What judges are looking for

Judges will look for founder-level signal in four places:

- A real problem with a specific customer.
- Evidence that the team understands the market, buyer, or user.
- A working product or credible prototype built during the hackathon.
- A clear pitch that shows why this team could keep going after June 6.

A beautiful demo with no buyer logic will score lower. A rough but specific product with strong customer understanding can still do very well.

Scoring rubric

Judges will score each project across six criteria.

Criterion	Weight	What strong looks like
Problem and customer clarity	20%	The team names a specific customer or user, explains the pain clearly, and avoids vague “everyone” markets.
Market and business potential	20%	The opportunity is plausible, the buyer or distribution path makes sense, and the team can explain why this could become a real company.

Product execution and demo	20%	The team built something concrete during the hackathon. The product works enough to demonstrate the core idea, even if it is not fully polished.
AI-native leverage and technical approach	15%	AI is used as a meaningful capability, not decoration. The technical choices support the product and the team can explain what was built.
Evidence, insight, and founder edge	15%	The team shows some real insight: customer knowledge, domain expertise, early validation, relevant data, or a strong reason they are the right people to build it.
Pitch clarity	10%	The 3-minute pitch is clear, direct, and judge-friendly. The team explains the problem, product, evidence, and next step without hiding behind buzzwords.

Scoring scale

Score	Meaning
90-100	Exceptional: clear startup potential, strong founder signal, credible product, sharp pitch.
70-89	Strong: above average, real promise, some gaps but clearly worth attention.
50-69	Solid: understandable and relevant, but missing sharpness, evidence, or execution depth.

30-49	Early or unclear: interesting pieces, but major gaps in problem, product, market, or pitch.
1-29	Not competitive: unclear, mostly generic, not sufficiently built, or hard to evaluate fairly.

Scores are meant to separate clear startup signal from projects that are still too vague, generic, or unfinished to evaluate well.

What counts as evidence

Evidence does not need to be perfect. It does need to be real enough to change how judges see the project.

Useful evidence can include:

- A specific customer or user segment, not a broad category.
- A conversation, quote, pain point, or example from the target market.
- Domain knowledge from the team's own work, study, network, or lived experience.
- A small market scan: competitors, alternatives, current workflows, or why existing tools fail.
- A working demo of the core workflow.
- A GitHub repo with commit history from the day.
- A clear next step: who you would test with next, what you would charge, or what you would build next.

Weak evidence:

- "The market is huge" with no customer detail.
- "Everyone needs this."
- Generic AI trend slides.
- A demo that looks good but does not prove the core use case.
- Old work presented as if it was built at the hackathon.

How judging works on the day

Teams submit by 19:00:

- Required: public GitHub repo with README and commit history from the day.
- Required: pitch deck, max 7 slides.
- Optional: hosted preview URL, if available.

You do not need to submit a demo video. Everyone pitches live on-site, and you can demo your product during the pitch if it helps judges understand the core workflow.

After submission, judges begin review and preliminary pitch rooms open.

- Preliminary round: every team pitches in an assigned room.
- Format: 3 minutes per team, no Q&A in preliminaries.
- Judges use the rubric above plus submitted materials.
- Judges review the submissions and preliminary pitches, then select the finalists.
- Expected finalists: around 6 teams.
- Final round: 3 minutes pitch + 2 minutes Q&A per finalist.
- Winners are announced after the final round.

What does not matter as much

Do not over-optimize for theatre.

Judges are not mainly looking for:

- The prettiest slide deck.
- A giant TAM slide with no buyer logic.
- The most complicated architecture.
- A perfect production-grade product.
- A long feature list.
- A generic AI wrapper with startup vocabulary attached.

A focused product with a specific customer and honest traction logic beats a broad, glossy pitch that could belong to any team.

Make your pitch judge-friendly

In 3 minutes, make the judge's job easy.

A strong structure:

1. The customer and problem.
2. What you built.
3. Why now / why this matters.
4. Evidence or founder edge.
5. What you would do next.

If you only fix one thing before pitching, fix your first sentence. It should tell judges who this is for and what painful thing you solve.

Good first sentence shape:

"We help [specific customer] do [specific painful job] because today they are stuck with [bad current workaround]."

Fairness and integrity

The hackathon is for product work built during the event.

Allowed:

- Ideas, research, notes, sketches, and customer understanding prepared before June 6.
- Generic templates, libraries, APIs, no-code tools, and open-source packages.
- Existing domain knowledge and existing relationships.

Not allowed:

- Presenting a mostly finished product as hackathon work.
- Importing a mostly finished private project-specific codebase and presenting it as work built during the day.
- Faking repo history, demo functionality, users, revenue, or customer evidence.

Organizers and judges may inspect GitHub history and ask questions if something looks off.

Final reminder

The winning projects will probably not be the most polished. They will be the ones where judges can see a real founder-builder path: a specific problem, credible product, useful AI leverage, honest evidence, and a team that can keep moving after the room closes.